

IN CONTEXT

Romantic background

List's work inspired a surge of interest in German mythology, not just among Nazis. The musical genius Richard Wagner created the most lasting artistic expressions when he fused Germanic myth with opera in *Der Ring des Nibelungen* ("The Ring Cycle"), an epic cycle of four operas (which Hitler saw as a supreme demonstration of German greatness). The Bavarian king, Ludwig II, also an admirer of Wagner, recreated his mythical operatic world in fairy-tale medieval-style castles perched on romantically forested mountainsides.

Neuschwanstein Castle, Bavaria, commissioned by Ludwig II and completed in 1886, was inspired by Richard Wagner's *The Ring Cycle*.



and wisdom and the father of Thor. List promoted Wotanism, a religious movement that he believed revived the values of pre-Christian German people. List was driven by his *völkisch* (nationalistic) belief in a Germanic community of racially pure Aryans who, he claimed, had been suppressed by Christian teaching. Such theories, far from historically accurate, were later adopted by the Nazis.

From 1902, the occult, particularly the religion of theosophy (see pp.238–239), increasingly colored List's Germanic nationalism. He was a strong advocate of the power of runes (see pp.68–69), and claimed that his intuitive readings of runes allowed him to access hidden knowledge about Germany's pagan past. He also believed that World War I would herald the emergence of a new, Aryan German empire.

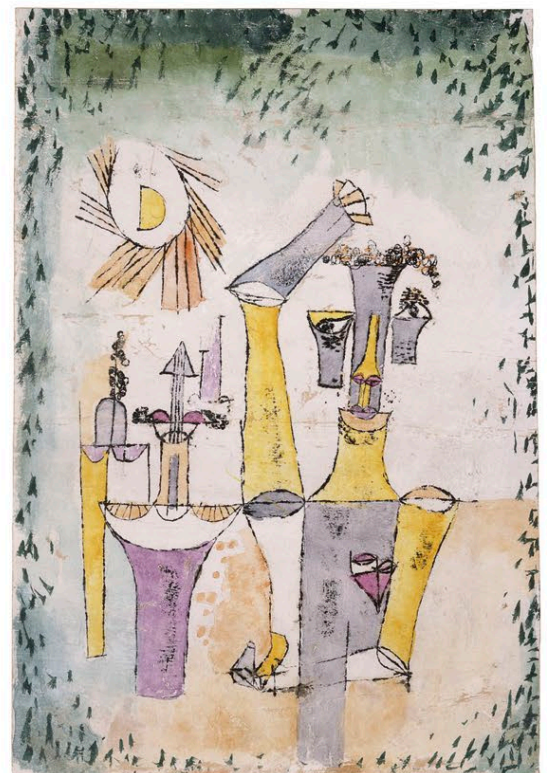
Spiritual brotherhood

In contrast with List's focus on Germanic paganism, the goal of the Ordo Templi Orientis was a fusion of all higher magical learning and the

creation of a brotherhood to spread spiritual and philosophical knowledge. Created in 1902 by two Germans, Carl Keller and Theodor Reuss, it embraced every form of occult teaching, from Freemasonry and the Kabbalah to Rosicrucianism. The order aimed to enable people to gain an ultimate understanding of existence, the universe, and spirituality. From 1910, it was dominated by Aleister Crowley (see pp.250–251), who merged it with his own religion, Thelema, and wrote its Gnostic Mass, which combined Thelemic ritual with some of the structures of the Catholic Mass. Such rites were led by ministers of the Ecclesia Gnostica Catholica, an arm of the Ordo Templi Orientis that operated as a church. Unlike its near-contemporary, the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn (see pp.242–243), the Ordo Templi Orientis still survives today.

▼ Esoteric art

This 1920 watercolor by the Swiss painter Paul Klee, entitled *Black Magic*, is thought to depict the artist as a magician. The German occult revival inspired many artists, and some critics claim that Klee's work was influenced by Spiritualism (see pp.224–227).



“Our Order possesses the key
which opens up all Masonic and
Hermetic secrets ...”

THEODOR REUSS, *ORIFLAMME*, 1912